

The Epistemology of the Author of the Pātañjalayogaśāstra-vivaraṇa

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1. Introduction

Pramāṇa—valid means of knowledge in the following context—is one of the most widely discussed topics in philosophical Sanskrit writings. In the Pātañjalayogaśāstra (PYŚ)—the combination of the so-called Yogasūtra and the so-called Yogabhāṣya¹—*sūtra* 1.6 lists the five *cittavṛttis* (activities of mind): *pramāṇa*, *viparyaya*, *vikalpa*, *nidrā*, and *smṛti*.² What are accepted as *pramāṇa* are listed in the next *sūtra*. They are: *pratyakṣa*, *anumāna* and *āgama*.³ There are no *sūtras* dedicated to define each of them but the Bhāṣya describes them.

There is a commentary on the PYŚ, or a sub-commentary on the Yogabhāṣya, ascribed to Śaṅkara. We call it the Pātañjalayogaśāstravivaraṇa (Vivaraṇa).⁴ It often dedicates substantial amount of text to discuss certain issues that its author deemed worth.⁵ The discussion on *pramāṇa* is one of them. He spends much effort expounding his views on various issues surrounding *pramāṇa*. The author's goal is in essence to explain and defend the Sūtra and the Bhāṣya. But from the topics he discusses, we can have some ideas of the surroundings he was in. There are also hints of somewhat unique philosophy he had.

2. The Vivaraṇa on *pratyakṣa*

The part I am concerned in this article is the introduction of sūtras 1.6 and 7 to the discussion on *pratyakṣa* in the Vivaraṇa, corresponding to p. 18, l. 25–p. 25, l. 20 in the 1952 Madras edition. It forms a unit. The text of the Bhāṣya on *pratyakṣa* appears simple enough.⁶ Yet the author of the Vivaraṇa produces his own structured discussions and weaves the words of the root text into it. The resulting structure of discussions is as follows, based on the edition currently being prepared:⁷ The sections typeset in the bold incorporate the text of the root texts, i.e., of the Yogasūtra and the Bhāṣya on it.⁸

1. Sūtras 1.6 and 7 plus the Bhāṣya on *pratyakṣa*

2. *Pratyakṣa* and *viśeṣa*

1. Why the Bhāṣya says *pratyakṣa* is mainly concerned with difference
2. Criticism of the [Buddhist] view that *sāmānya* is unreal

3. *Yogipratyakṣa* and *mānasapratyakṣa*

1. Question: Are they separate *pramāṇa*(s) or kinds of *pratyakṣa*?

2. Answer: ***Pratyakṣa***

4. *Pramāṇaphala* (The result of *pramāṇa*)

1. Two views to be examined: *pramāṇa* and its *phala* are identical; there is an independent *phala*
2. There is no independent *pramāṇaphala*
3. *Siddhāntas*
 1. No independent *phala*, nor are *pramāṇa* and *phala* identical
 2. The *phala* is not the resulting *dravya* (a thing), either
 3. The *phala* is a special state of *dravya*

4. Either *kriyā* or *dravya* is figuratively the *phala* of the other
 1. Opponent: the *phala* is only figurative?
 2. Answer: yes
 3. Opponent: then, the result being more or less erroneous, no reason to pursue *pramāṇa*
 4. Answer: correct
 5. *samyagdarśana* [rather than *pramāṇa/pratyakṣa*] brings about *nivṛtti* [i.e., *mokṣa*]
 6. *Mokṣa* is brought about only by *samyagdarśana* (not by *pramāṇa* that leads to action)

4. The reason why *puruṣa*'s nature—being aware of *buddhi*—is not established here/

Explanation of the intent of the Bhāṣya's last statement with regard to *pratyakṣa*

1. Criticism of the Naiyāyika position of *pratyakṣa*, including their position on *pramāṇaphala*
 1. Examinations of the view that a cognition is a result of contact
 2. Examinations of the view that ideas of taking or removing are the result of *pramāṇa*
2. The problem of *saṃvedyatva* of *cittavṛtti*
 1. Is *pramāṇa* a *karaṇa*, one of *kāraṇas*?
 2. *Siddhānta*: *cittavṛtti* is *saṃvedya* as the revealer (*abhivyañjaka*)
 1. Why is the eyesight not grasped while it is an *abhivyañjaka*?
 1. According to the theory that sense faculties are material
 2. According to the theory that sense faculties are not material
5. Conclusion: *pramāṇaphala* is what the Bhāṣya says it is
 1. Question: How is *cittavṛtti* object of awareness (*saṃvedya*)? Answer: Not as *pratyakṣa*

2. Final word on *pramāṇaphala*

Although there are a number of interesting points worth discussing, I will discuss only two points that testify to the author's philosophy in the following.

3. *Yogipratyakṣa* and *Mānasapratyakṣa*

One question that the author of the Vivaraṇa deals with is the position of the yogins' cognition and internal sensations. Some may apply terms such as *yogipratyakṣa* and *mānasapratyakṣa* respectively to those concepts. The terms are not used in the Vivaraṇa but certainly the author was aware of the rich discussions surrounding these two. The problem for him was that neither the sūtra nor the Bhāṣya refers to those concepts. Even more problematic was the fact that the Bhāṣya used the word *indriyapranāḍikayā* ("by means of sense faculties") in describing *pratyakṣa*. If one applies this characterization as a condition for a cognition to fall into *pratyakṣa*, then *yogipratyakṣa* and *mānasapratyakṣa* fail. The author of the Vivaraṇa tries to solve these two well-known categories failing to be accounted for in the Pātañjala system of *cittavṛttis* (activities of mind).

His solution to these problems are 1) that they belong to *pratyakṣa*, as in many other systems;⁹ 2) they are not specifically mentioned in the Bhāṣya because its description of *pratyakṣa* already covers them; and 3) the mention of sense faculties is there just to cover ordinary people's *pratyakṣa*.

In my reconstruction of the text, the question and answer appear as follows:

[q] nanu ca yogināṃ nirvikalpasamādhijāṃ darśanam? tasyānevaṃlakṣaṇatvāt tathā
sukharāgādivijñānasya cānindriyapranādikāpūrvatvāt pramāṇāntaratvam abhyupetavyaṃ
pratyakṣatvaṃ vā vaktavyam

[a] ucyate—nal pratyakṣasya puruṣapratyayāpekṣatvena parihṛtatvāt na hy apratyayā vṛttiḥ
pratyakṣam | caitanyodayahetor eva sapratyayāyāḥ pratyakṣatvam tathā cāha—**phalaṃ**
tadaviśiṣṭaḥ pauraṣeyaś cittavṛttibodha itill

There are no significant differences between this text and the 1952 edition in the question part.¹⁰ On the other hand, I have introduced a conjectural emendation in the beginning of the answer part. It starts with “ucyate—*nal pratyakṣasya puruṣapratyayāpekṣatvena parihṛtatvāt*.” This is against the reading “*ucyate na pramāṇasya...*” that is attested in primary witnesses.¹¹ The main reason why the text needs to be emended is the word *puruṣapratyayāpekṣatva* used in the answer. This is one of expressions our author uses to characterize *pratyakṣa*, being inspired by the sentence in the Bhāṣya: *phalaṃ tadaviśiṣṭaḥ pauraṣeyaś cittavṛttibodhaḥ* that he quotes as part of the answer (typeset in the bold above). Our author appears to take this sentence as the true definition of *pratyakṣa* as implied in the next paragraph.¹² There the expression is *tadaviśiṣṭapuruṣapratyayaphalāvasānatvāt pratyakṣatā siddhaiva*. In other words, what results in the effect (*phala*) that is a notion belonging to *puruṣa* [but] not distinguished from the activity (*tad* refers to *vṛtti*) is *pratyakṣa*, according to our author. Hence, in the beginning of the answer section, too, the phrase *puruṣapratyayāpekṣatvena* should be about *pratyakṣa*, not *pramāṇa*. With my emendation, the first part of the answer should be understood as “No. For, [the necessity to accept those two kinds of cognition to be other kinds of *pramāṇa* or the necessity to state that they nonetheless belong to *pratyakṣa*] are precluded since *pratyakṣa* presupposes

notions belonging to *puruṣa* (i.e., as long as an activity of mind (*cittavṛtti*) produces a notion belonging to *puruṣa*, it is *pratyakṣa*).”

There may be other possibilities of emendation but the point the author should be pushing forward is that those two cognitions are still *pratyakṣa* because they generate a notion on *puruṣa*’s side. This understanding of what constitute *pratyakṣa* appears unique. I have not found anything like this being discussed in the context of definition of *pratyakṣa*.

4. *Pramāṇaphala* and Distrust of *Pramāṇa*

As the outline above shows, much of the text on *pratyakṣa* is in fact a discussion on *pramāṇaphala* (the result of valid means of knowledge). The most notable in this discussion is our author’s distrust of *pramāṇa*.¹³ This shows up as section 4.3.4 in the outline above. There our author has a conversation with a hypothetical opponent who find it problematic that the proponent holds that the *pramāṇaphala* is only figurative, i.e., unreal.¹⁴ Our author concedes that the primary result of *pramāṇa* belongs to *puruṣa* in its mistaken state (*mithyābhūtaśyaiva mukhyaphalatvaṃ vṛttyākāraśya*), and that an experience (*bhoga*) accompanied by activities of mind (*cittavṛtti*) is nothing but wrong (*mithyābhūta eva vṛtṭyanugato bhogaḥ*). He does not just concede these points but goes on to say that those who think *pramāṇaphala* is not mistaken will not have *mokṣa* (*yeṣāṃ amithyā phalam teṣāṃ...mokṣābhāvaḥ*).¹⁵ He is saying that *pramāṇa* binds a person to *saṃsāra*. This last point should raise some eyebrows. It sounds quite unusual.¹⁶

It may sound unusual but not an unfamiliar one. There is a very famous person who also thought *pramāṇa* not to be conducive to the final goal. He also talked ill of *pramāṇa* and those

who give much importance to it. It is Śaṅkara, the author of the Brahmasūtraśāṅkarabhāṣya, whose identity with the author of the Vivaraṇa is the biggest question regarding the Vivaraṇa. In the beginning of the commentary on the Brahmasūtra, he tells us how *pramāṇas* and *śāstras* (obviously he means *pratyakṣa* and *anumāna* as *pramāṇa* and *śāstra* as independent) have the domain that comes from *avidyā*.¹⁷ The first part of the answer explains why *pramāṇa* is possible only when there is the misidentification of what is not “I” or “mine” as “I” or “mine.”¹⁸ In the second paragraph, Śaṅkara is being sarcastic. He likens the educated (*vyutpattimat*) people to animals. What Śaṅkara has in mind is this idea that *pramāṇa* eventually results in *pravṛtti* (taking action) or *nivṛtti* (stopping action). And that is not desirable from his well-known standpoint of no-action.

5. Final Remarks

Despite the substantial effort to discuss *pramāṇa*, the author of the Pātañjalayogaśāstravivaraṇa is sceptical of the utility of *pramāṇa* when it comes to *mokṣa* as we have seen above. This, I think, is a noteworthy, especially because he still accepts *samyagdarśana* to be the cause of *mokṣa*. Apparently it is not something one gains by *pramāṇa*. At this point, the refusal to acknowledge the utility of *pramāṇa* for *mokṣa* even appears personal. On the other hand, Śaṅkara’s lack of interest regarding *pramāṇa* has been noted.¹⁹ Again, as is well-known, Śaṅkara’s position is that the knowledge brings about *mokṣa* and the knowledge comes from the Upaniṣads. Apparently, again, the Upaniṣads are not part of *pramāṇa* for him. The sarcastic tone about the educated people appears to reflect his personal dislike of philosophers who endlessly discussed *pramāṇa*. The Vivaraṇa and the BSBh talk about *pramāṇa* being ultimately wrong in quite different contexts. Wordings are also completely different (it is hard to postulate borrowings). What are shared are the conclusion and the beliefs

that lead to the conclusion: that *pramāṇa* makes a person to act; and actions are the opposite of the final salvation. The sarcastic passage in the *Brahmasūtrabhāṣya* and the following sarcastic conclusion to the discussion on *pramāṇaphala* in the *Vivaraṇa* read like from the same sense of sarcasm to me:

tasmāt pramāṇaphalābhijñānābhīmānamātram eva kevalaṃ paṇḍitammanyānām ity upekṣaṇīyam itill

(In conclusion, just a pure arrogant misconception about the term *pramāṇaphala* simply belongs to those who mistakenly consider themselves to be learned; it should simply be ignored.)

That was exactly what Śaṅkara did in the *Brahmasūtrabhāṣya*.

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Notes

¹ See Wezler 1983, 17-18, Bronkhorst 1985, 203, and Maas 2006, xii–xix.

² *pramāṇaviparyayavikalpanidrāsmṛtayah*||6||

³ *pratyakṣānumānāgamāḥ pramāṇānī*||7||

⁴ For the title of the text, see Harimoto 2014, 9.

⁵ For example, the Vivaraṇa has an extensive commentary Īśvara.

⁶ The version that the author of the Vivaraṇa knew was as follows: *indriyapraṇāḍikayā cittasya bāhyavastūparāgāt tadviṣayā sāmānyaviśeṣātmano 'rthasya viśeṣāvadhāraṇapradhānā vṛttiḥ pratyakṣam pramāṇam phalaṁ tadaviśiṣṭaḥ pauruṣeyaś cittavṛttibodhaḥ pratisaṃvedī buddheḥ puruṣa ity upariṣṭāt pravedayiṣyāmaḥ*. There are a few text critical issues that ought to be discussed regarding this version of the Bhāṣya text. They will be discussed elsewhere in the future. The variants in various transmissions of the Yogabhāṣya (see Maas 2006, 12–13) do not have immediate effects in the following discussion.

⁷ The part corresponds to p. 18, l. 25–p. 25, l. 19 of the 1952 Madras edition. For general introduction to the text critical situation and the relationship between witnesses of the Vivaraṇa, see Harimoto 2014, 15–43. A few things are worth noting here: First, There are only two key witnesses to the text. Both are palm-leaf manuscripts written in the Malayalam script. One is from Trivandrum and the other is preserved in Lahore. The remaining witnesses all derive from either of the two palm-leaf manuscripts. This includes the 1952 edition.

⁸ One may note that the order of the topics follows that of the Pramāṇasamuccaya of Dignāga.

⁹ For example, both the Buddhists and the Naiyāyikas include the two in pratyakṣa.

¹⁰ The only difference is that the 1952 edition reads cānindriyapraṇāḍī° instead of cānindriyapraṇāḍikā°. This reading was due to the disruption of folio orders in the Lahore manuscript that ultimately was the source of the 1952 edition. And this disruption recorded in the edition helped establish the close relationship between the available manuscripts of the Vivaraṇa. See Harimoto 2014, 26–29.

¹¹ Apparently the editors of the 1952 edition was also uncomfortable with this reading and they suggested an emendation. It reads: *ucyatel pratyakṣasya (na pramāṇasya) puruṣapratyayāpekṣatvena parihṛtatvāt*. What the editors meant here was that their source read “na pramāṇasya” but they reject the reading and introduce *pratyakṣasya* instead.

¹² *evaṃ ca sati sukharāgādijñānasya kliṣṭākliṣṭarūpasya*

tadaviśiṣṭapuruṣapratyayaphalāvasāna-tvāt pratyakṣatā siddhaivall (That being the case, it is very much established that the cognition of pleasure, wish, etc., which can be either wholesome or not wholesome, is *pratyakṣa* since it ends up with the effect that is the notion belonging to *puruṣa* but not distinguished from it [the cognition].)

¹³ Some of the other points the author of the Vivaraṇa makes with regard to *pramāṇaphala* are as follows: there is no independent *pramāṇaphala*; nor *pramāṇa* itself is its *phala*; either action [resulting from *pramāṇa*] or a state of *dravya* [the *pramāṇa* causes man to seek] is mutually figuratively the *phala*; *pramāṇa* does not lead to *mokṣa*; the Naiyāyikas' definition of *pratyakṣa* is wrong; the view that the *phala* is one of the desire to take, that to remove/avoid, or being impartial is wrong; *cittavṛtti* is the revealer (*abhivyañjaka*) for *puruṣa*; *puruṣa*'s being aware of *cittavṛtti* is itself not *pratyakṣa*.

¹⁴ “*nanu ca bhavato 'py upacaritam eva phalam, vṛttyaviśiṣṭāyāḥ phalatvenābhyupagamāṇī puruṣasya ca śuddhatvāt, tadākāratāyā anṛtatvaml...* (Opponent: For you, too, the result [of *pramāṇa*] is nothing but figurative. For, [the state (*avasthā*) of *puruṣa*] not distinguished from activities [of mind] is accepted as the result [of *pramāṇa* by you]. Also, since *puruṣa* is pure, that [*puruṣa*] has the shape of them [i.e., activities of mind (*cittavṛtti*)] is erroneous.)” This part corresponds to p. 22, ll. 14–15 in the 1952 Madras edition. I do not propose any major changes to the reading.

¹⁵ “*ata eva ca samyagdarśanād ātyantikī nivṛttir upapadyatell yeṣāṃ amithyā phalaṃ teṣāṃ vairāgyakāraṇābhāvāt, samyagdarśanānveṣaṇānupapatter mokṣābhāvaḥ na ca kriyāpariniṣpādyo mokṣaḥ, anityatvaprasaṅgātll*” This part is 4.3.4.5 and 4.3.4.6 in the outline. The text corresponds to p. 22, ll. 23–26 of the 1952 edition. Note that our author equates *mokṣa* with ultimate cessation (*ātyantikī nivṛttiḥ*) and that he distinguishes *samyagdarśana* (the right view) from *pramāṇa*, primarily *pratyakṣa* in this context.

¹⁶ There are a few things that should be noted about this position. One is that, as the author of the Vivaraṇa repeatedly exhibits, he believes that salvation is brought about by knowledge (*jñāna*). Apparently, however, *pramāṇa* does not bring it. As he clearly states in the 4.3.4.5 and 4.3.4.6 of the outline (see the note above), *samyagdarśana* brings about *nivṛtti* (cessation) and that is salvation (*mokṣa*). See, in this connexion, his explanation of the sūtra 1.1, which is translated in Harimoto 2014, 187–193. There, he insists that the goal (*prayojana*) of the Pātañjalayogaśāstra is cessation (*nivṛtti*) and its means is *vivekakhyāti* (discriminative knowledge), which he sometimes paraphrases as *samyagdarśana*. Especially notes 344 on p. 188 and n. 356 on p. 191 are relevant.

¹⁷ *kathaṃ punar avidyāvadviṣayāṇi pratyakṣādīni pramāṇāni śāstrāṇi cetil*

*ucyate—dehendriyādiṣv ahaṃmamābhimānarahitasya pramāṭṛtvānupapattau
pramāṇapravṛtṭyanupapatteḥl na hīndriyāṇy anupādāya pratyakṣādivyavahāraḥ saṃbhavatil na
cādhiṣṭhānam antareṇendriyāṇāṃ vyavahāraḥ saṃbhavatil na cānadyastātmabhāvena
dehena kaścīd vyāpriyatel na caitasmin sarvasminn asati asaṅgasyātmanaḥ pramāṭṛtvam
upapadyatel na ca pramāṭṛtvam antareṇa pramāṇapravṛtṭir astil tasmād avidyāvadviṣayāṇy eva
pratyakṣādīni pramāṇāni śāstrāṇi ca*

*paśvādibhiś cāviśeṣātI yathā hi paśvādayaḥ śabdādibhiḥ śrotrādīnāṃ saṃbandhe sati,
śabdādivijñāne pratikūle jāte tato nivartante, anukūle ca pravartante; yathā daṇḍodyatakaram
puruṣam abhimukham upalabhya māṃ hantum ayam icchatīti palāyitum ārabhante,
haritatṛṇapūrṇapāṇim upalabhya taṃ praty abhimukhībhavanti; evaṃ puruṣā api
vyutpannacittāḥ krūrādṛṣṭīn ākrośataḥ khaḍgodyatakarān balavata upalabhya tato nivartante,
tadviparītān prati pravartante, ataḥ samānaḥ paśvādibhiḥ puruṣāṇāṃ
pramāṇaprameyavyavahāraḥl paśvādīnāṃ ca prasiddho 'vivekapuraḥsaraḥ
pratyakṣādivyavahāraḥ, tatsāmānyadarśanād vyutpattimatām api puruṣāṇāṃ
pratyakṣādivyavahāras tatkālaḥ samāna iti niścīyatel (BSSBh NSP ed. pp. 40–43)*

¹⁸ He appears to be talking how the action (*pravṛtti*) of the verb *pramā-* is not possible from the *kāraka* (*karāṇa*, *adhikarāṇa?*, *karṭṛ*, at least) point of view in the first paragraph of the answer, starting with *ucyate*, in the passage quoted in the previous note.

¹⁹ See, for example, Mayeda 1979, 47.